Gender insecurity, either experienced directly by women or by other women in their community, motivates women to join or support the KIO/KIA. Female soldiers believe the organization will provide them, and their community, with protection:[6]

> Sometimes I had to go to the village to find supplies. But even though I have a pistol, I felt unsafe and very nervous about the enemy … I feel unsafe for a long time. Only when I can turn back to liberated areas and I am sure I am inside the territory controlled by our troops, I feel relief.[7]

Table 4.3. Gender equality indicators, Kachin State

2015	Myanmar Census, Kachin State data [8]	Male literary rate	94.1%
		Female literacy rate	89.4 %
		Male labour force participation (15+)	83.6 %
		Female labour force participation (15+)	43.5 %
		Female-headed households	27.3 %
		Infant mortality rate	53 (per 1000 live births)
		Under five mortality rate	61 (per 1000 live births)
		Percentage of households with access to tap water	5.2 %
		Percentage of households using firewood for cooking	72.8 %

Source: Union of Myanmar (2015a)

Research has found a significant link between gender equality and peace, showing that countries where women are experiencing high levels of violence are more likely to engage in conflict and war (both within and between countries) compared to countries with low levels of violence against women (Hudson et al. 2008). Countries where women have greater equality and greater political representation are also less likely to become involved in wars. There is then a relationship between marginalization, gender inequality, and conflict (Caprioli 2005; Hudson 2005). As shown below, a climate of gendered insecurity motivates women to support the armed forces. However, as women's experiences of insecurity are heightened by their unequal status within the KIO/KIA, the relationship between women's inequality in accessing resources, access, and power, and their participation in political violence is more complex than assumed.